GIS Treasure Mapping: The Bounties and Booby Traps of a Public Database of Pre-Archaeological Excavations

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This paper introduces a digital database and GIS mapping project that compiles and visualizes treasure-hunting excavations across the early modern Hispanic world. Treasure hunting was the premodern precursor to archaeological excavations. Long before archaeology, medieval and early modern people sought and routinely disinterred artifacts that would have considerable historical and scientific value if they had been located today. To better understand our surviving material heritage in the twenty-first century, it is important to understand the centuries of predation it has faced at the hands of licensed treasure hunters. These excavations were authorized and documented by Spanish royal and colonial authorities, but the archival records pertaining to this phenomenon are not well-known among scholars or the public. This project uses ArcGIS to map and compile data from several dozen excavations, and will ultimately be hosted publicly, allowing scholars, archaeologists, students, and the public to gain a better sense of premodern disturbances of the archaeological record. I seek feedback from the Digital Humanities community to better understand how to make this a useful tool for a variety of users, and how to navigate the dangers in publicly hosting information about vulnerable sites of archaeological value.

Though they differ sharply in intention, both treasure-hunters and archaeologists alter landscapes and the situation of material culture dramatically, fundamentally transforming the sites they target. Archaeologists are often able to tell if a historic place has been entered and looted in the past, but it is difficult to understand the historical context or to accurately date such incursions. This project compiles a variety of data that I have gathered from archives in Spain, Mexico, Colombia, and Peru, dating primarily from the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. Users will gain a sense not only of the geography and topography of premodern excavations but also be able to view the archival signatures that correspond with each site. The database will show where and when these archival documents were originally created and contain information about the governing officials who were involved, the taxation rates granted to treasure hunters, and the types of treasure (funereal, votive, practical, accidental, etc.) targeted in each excavation. These fields will be searchable, and it will also be possible to sort the excavations chronologically, to better understand what areas were excavated as the Spanish Empire developed and expanded over centuries. This map and database can provide unique insights into the phenomenon of treasure hunting in the premodern period, while also offering scholars and the public a novel means of understanding the impacts of pre-archaeological incursions into historical and sacred sites.

Scholars may be familiar with descriptions of these excavations in chronicles. Garcilaso de la Vega, "the Inca," describes a man riding a horse whose foot sank into an ancient tomb filled with gold and silver vessels, and a group of Spaniards who drained a lake near Cuzco where they suspected Inca treasures could be found (Vega et al. 1966: 749; Vega et al. 1961: 121). Though these details might be interesting as curiosities, there is a relatively unexplored yet rich body of documentation that can be used to more fully understand these excavations and their long term impacts. Cases just like those in the chronicles can be identified and studied through their surviving licenses and excavation records. Julio de Aroio, for example, was out riding his horse near Chanchon, Colombia, in 1670, rounding up cattle, when his horse's foot sank into the grass revealing "a very deep hole which in its construction appears to me to be a burial site of the ancient *indios* (AGNC,VISITAS-SANT.SC.62,10,D.7,f657r-657v)." In 1707, two residents of Bogotá were authorized to drain the Laguna de Bochica in Chipaque. The men "achieved its drainage in a few days," noting that "many flat stones have been found which seem to be placed by hand because they are in order and continuous (AGNC,MISCELANEA,SC.39,66,D.28,f.244r-245v)." Details of these discoveries, including measurements of the excavation sites, methods and tools used by treasure hunters, and descriptions of disinterred artifacts, survive in archival records. A compilation and visualization of such data will provide new insights into historical sites that were transformed or destroyed centuries before the establishment of UNESCO World Heritage Sites and international artifact trafficking laws.

This project aims to build on the success of other initiatives like the Coin Hoards of the Roman Em-

pire Project, which has proven the utility in developing a publicly accessible and large-scale map of otherwise isolated archaeological sites and material history (Mairat, et al. 2022). But a mapped database of treasure excavation sites in ArcGIS can be valuable not only for archaeologists; mapping also reveals migratory patterns in the premodern world, sacred landscapes that have faded from memory, and the peculiarities of laws that authorized the destruction of cultural heritage long before the first efforts in scientific preservation. Pre-Columbian golden artifacts appear in museums and private collections across the world, and a public registry of excavations may help to reveal the provenance of some of these dislocated pieces of cultural heritage. The several dozen excavation records and treasure-hunting licenses I have collected vary in detail, but together they reveal a web of sacred sites, ancient artifact deposits, and a transcontinental network of premodern travelers. This project will contribute to increasingly important conversations about the use of digital tools in both preserving and showcasing cultural heritage. Looting archaeological sites remains a problem throughout the world, so it is crucial to design this resource in a manner that facilitates the preservation, rather than increased exploitation, of vulnerable sites and artifacts. Presenting this work-in-progress at DH 2025 would offer the opportunity to receive invaluable feedback on the utility and pitfalls of this publicly accessible digital treasure-hunting map and database.

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